

+ Prime focus

Sustainability Loan takes the bite out of wild dogs



QRIDA Client Scott Counsell with the exclusion fence he installed with the help of a Sustainability Loan from QRIDA

The loan helped Scott fund the installation of an exclusion fence to protect his livestock and pastures from ongoing feral pest damage.

“Our business was able to purchase fencing materials and then construct the exclusion fence to enclose approximately 22,000 acres (8,900 ha) quickly,” said Scott.

“The Sustainability Loan has allowed us to fence our property under tough seasonal and financial times.”

Scott highly recommends other producers facing similar challenges with feral pest damage to look into how a Sustainability Loan from QRIDA could help them.

“Our experience working with QRIDA has been positive and it was relatively easy to complete an application in order to source the funding.”

“I would definitely recommend the service of QRIDA and I have also informed other graziers of the benefits of being a part of this project,” he said.

For more information about how a Sustainability Loan could help you, look online at www.qrida.qld.gov.au or contact us on Freecall 1800 623 946.

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Fourth generation grazer, Scott Counsell has grown up in a wool shed. Raised on a sheep station in Barcaldine in Central Western Queensland, he spent every opportunity working the property alongside his family.

After finishing school, Scott obtained his wool classers' stencil which landed him jobs in wool sheds across Queensland and parts of the United States. After returning home from working abroad, Scott was offered the chance to manage one of his parent's stations, 'Lyndon'.

“Lyndon is 45,000 acres (18,200 ha) and I manage it with my wife (Sharon) and sister (Frances). We currently run beef, sheep and goats,” said Scott.

As dry conditions continued to grip Western Queensland, wild dogs began to enclose on Scott's property making it impractical to run sheep.

Scott says that feral pests were causing damage not only to his livestock but also his pastures.

“We couldn't viably run our sheep operation due to the increased presence of the pests and predators,” he said

“The huge numbers put pressure on what little pasture was left.”

“The Sustainability Loan has allowed us to fence our property under tough seasonal and financial times...”

The resulting decrease in productivity and profits caused by the feral pests led Scott and his family to consider exclusion fencing and apply for a Sustainability Loan through the Queensland Rural and Industry Development Authority (QRIDA).

From the CEO's desk



QRIDA CEO Cameron MacMillan (far right) with QRIDA Chair Wayne Carlson (back) visiting QRIDA clients Ange & Lionel Smith (centre front) with the QRIDA Board & Roma Regional Area Manager Tony Koch (second from right)

It's hard to believe that 2018 is coming to an end already, but it is a good time to reflect on the year that was for our clients and organisation. Of course, one of the biggest challenges our clients have faced this year was the ongoing severity of the drought.

Tough climatic conditions have taken its toll on producers across the state, but QRIDA is proud to be standing by them in these tough times, offering support to existing clients and providing additional finance options like our Sustainability Loans to help producers improve their current operations to become more drought tolerant and sustainable.

Since January, we've also been able to offer our new Farm Debt Restructure Office advisory services to primary producers experiencing financial difficulties due to drought and other factors to help them make informed decisions about the future of their farming business.

While the media captured the physical and emotional resilience of our state's producers the 2017 Rural Debt Survey showed their financial resilience, reporting that overall rural debt rose by less than 2 per cent to \$17.2 billion as at December 2017.

Family farm succession continues as a key focus for QRIDA with over \$1.6 million approved in Farm Management Grants to help with the cost of professional planning advice and our First Start Loans of up to \$2 million enabling more young people make their start in agriculture.

In November, QRIDA's board visited Charleville and Augathella to meet with local graziers to discuss drought, exclusion fencing, carbon farming and the sheep and goat industry. Sadly, this was the last trip for QRIDA Chairperson, Wayne Carlson, who has announced his retirement from the Board after nine years as a Director including six years as Chair. Wayne's passion for rural and regional Queensland, industry experience and leadership has set a very high standard for everyone in our organisation. I'd like to thank Wayne for his contribution and dedication and wish him well in life after QRIDA.

I wish you a happy, safe and hopefully wet Christmas. We look forward to doing even more to support rural and regional Queensland in 2019.

- Cameron MacMillan

Options available for farm debt

QRIDA has a dedicated Farm Debt Services unit that provides farmers experiencing financial difficulties with assistance to make informed decisions about the future of their business. This unit manages the Farm Business Debt Mediation scheme as well as the Farm Debt Restructure Office.

The Farm Business Debt Mediation scheme prevents lenders from foreclosing on farming properties without first offering formal mediation. This gives farmers the chance to sit down with their bank and solve matters relating to farm business debt.

The Farm Debt Restructure Office administers Farm Business Analysis Assistance which enables farmers who are experiencing financial difficulties to access independent financial information and an analysis of their farm business.

This voluntary program identifies areas of benefit to improve the future of their enterprise.

These services were recently showcased at a series of events across regional Queensland on the Farm Debt Services Roadshow.

At the events QRIDA's Economist, Corrie Feldman, presented the 2017 Queensland Rural Debt Survey results from a regional perspective and Farm Business Debt Mediation Manager, John Simpson, explained the programs available to financial professionals in the regions.

"It was great to get out and about in regional Queensland to show local professionals the services available to them to help primary producers," John said.

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To find out more about these programs and how they can help you **Freecall 1800 623 946** or visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au.



Attendees at the Farm Debt Services Roadshow in Mackay

Supporting family farms to meet market challenges

Andy and Judy Veal are typical Queensland producers in many ways. The pair live and work on their avocado farm in Blackbutt with their adult children and their families. Everyone is involved in the family business.

The Veal family are no strangers to tough times, since recovering from drought in 2010 and dealing with damaging hail storms, the business has grown with help from QRIDA.

The Veals used a QRIDA Sustainability Loan to assist with the purchase of property and equipment to help expand and create greater resilience in their business.

“Having QRIDA there made a world of difference. We feel they really care and want to keep people on the land and that aligns with our goals too,” said Judy.

QRIDA has nine Regional Area Managers across Queensland who are able to meet on-farm to help with applications or discuss options for funding.

Andy talks candidly about their experience with QRIDA.

“Yes, there’s a lot of information required but it is no more than we already utilise ourselves to make informed decisions. You should be expected to understand your business and consider your plans; forethought is required to secure funding in today’s market,” he said.

Judy and Andy see information and feedback as one of the most valuable additions to their business operations.

“The quality assurance requirements set by our industry and retailers adds an additional level of work beyond producing the end product, but eventually you see the value in the information you have captured,” said Judy.



QRIDA Client Andy Veal at his family's avocado farm at Blackbutt. Below: some of the Veal's avocados ready for market

“It enables you to make informed business decisions that allow you to continually improve your production and profitability.”

The Veals say the greatest value in funding their on-farm improvements through QRIDA is the service they received during and after the application process.

“Making repayment arrangements with QRIDA means a conversation, we never feel like we’re going cap-in-hand,” said Judy.

“Flexibility and a real understanding of rural life, and what it means to be a primary producer in Queensland set QRIDA apart.”

Today the entire Veal family enjoy life living on-farm and, armed with an intimate knowledge of their business operations, the family is well supported to tackle whatever comes next.

Find out how a Sustainability Loan could make the difference to your business - contact QRIDA on Freecall 1800 623 946 or visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au/sustainability for more information.

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Keep track of your rainfall

Let’s hope for more favourable seasons in 2019. Keep track of the rainfall on your property with our easy to use online 2019 Rainfall Chart.

Download yours today from our website at www.qrida.qld.gov.au/rainfall-chart.

Festive season office closure



QRIDA will close for the festive season at 5pm on Monday 24 December 2018 and will reopen on Wednesday 2 January 2019.

From all of us at QRIDA, we wish you a very happy and safe festive season and thank you for your support during the year. We look forward to being in touch again in 2019!

+ Regional update



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Farm Management Grants helping families

It has been terrific to see the uptake of Farm Management Grants by farming families with the support of professionals in my region. The grants are open to all family members involved with farm succession and allow individuals to claim up to \$2,500 per annum. The grants will continue to be available until June 2019.

I would encourage all producers to start the conversation with both their immediate family and their professional advisors.

Once all the plans are laid out, QRIDA can assist in turning those plans into reality with our First Start Loan scheme.



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Rural Debt Survey results communicated

Over the past month I've assisted with meetings in Mackay, Ayr and Townsville detailing the recent Queensland Rural Debt Survey and provided details of QRIDA's Farm Debt Services. Meeting attendees were provided with state-based Rural Debt Survey results as well as detailed regionally based figures focusing on relevant industries in those areas.

The Farm Debt Restructure Office provides producers experiencing financial difficulties with access to independent expert financial analysis of their farm business to make better informed decisions to improve their business.



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Improved conditions increase confidence

In recent months I've been working closely with stakeholders to promote QRIDA's finance options to producers. I've been able to present this information to accountants and banks and have received very positive responses. Several people identified clients who could benefit from QRIDA's programs, specifically Sustainability Loans to upgrade their plant and equipment.

Seasonal conditions have improved across much of my region, which will provide confidence to producers for the coming season and in turn help them to focus on ways to improve and make their operations more efficient especially renewable energy sources for irrigators.



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Succession a hot topic

'Succession requires forward planning and good communication' is the clear message from recent discussions I've had with organisations advising primary producers and their families about rural succession. There are many pitfalls to come out of poor planning, and professional assistance with succession will pave the way for future generations to be successful. Farm Management Grants are a great way to cover the costs of this professional advice and our First Start Loans are designed for those wanting to succeed the previous generation in farming.

Call me to meet with you on-farm to discuss your options, help with business plans and applications.



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Busy time in the Burnett

There's been significant activity in the Burnett this year, with a number of family successions taking place and producers building a more resilient business through on-farm development despite difficult weather conditions and commodity price fluctuations.

As primary production diversifies and operations expand, QRIDA works closely with banks, accountants and financial planners to find the best lending solution for producers when more funding is required. If your herd is your asset, we're keen to help you take the next step to build a viable, sustainable and resilient enterprise through our First Start or Sustainability Loans.



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Improve water infrastructure with QRIDA

As the year marches towards Christmas, the spring storms are delivering some good falls of rain. The pastures across the Central Highlands are responding to this rain and beginning to bulk up. But unfortunately these natural light shows and rainfall events are not heading out west.

With water so precious, now's a great time to consider fencing off the dams and pumping the water to tanks and troughs to maintain the drinking quality of the water and reduce time spent retrieving stock from dams. QRIDA's Sustainability Loans can be used for property improvements and development projects such as these - contact me to find out more.



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First Starts paying off

It has been encouraging to have so many First Start Loan clients achieve their initial milestones and come back to QRIDA for loans to undertake additional development work.

First Start Loans are designed to assist applicants achieve full-time primary production on a staged basis. The loans can be used for a myriad of purposes including livestock purchases, exclusion fencing or increasing the number of watering points for more effective grazing and pasture management.

QRIDA is committed to promoting young people into primary production, so get in touch with me to discuss your plans.



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Talks of expansion promising

Having held temporary offices throughout the region in the last few months, I have been talking with many producers who are keen to develop their operation further or expand it to achieve ongoing profitability.

Some producers are seeing the current dry spell as an opportunity to plan and organise development to minimise the impact of the dry in the future.

No matter which stage you're currently at, I am keen to chat with you about where you want to be and how we can work together to achieve your goals. Contact me to find out more.



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Young interest in the North West

It's promising that the majority of my enquiries continue to be from younger people under 40 looking at a way to get into the industry.

It has been great to see that most of these applicants have taken steps to put themselves in a healthy financial state before choosing to take on the associated debt with our First Start Loan.

I'm always traveling throughout my area and can meet with you to discuss how QRIDA might assist with your plans. Phone me to make a time to meet either in my office at Cloncurry or on-property.

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